



Candi Prambanan

A massive religious compound that reflects the craftsmanship and architectural skill of ancient Hindu culture



△ TEMPLES OF THE HINDU DEITIES

The temple of Shiva (center, foreground) is flanked by the smaller temples of Vishnu and Brahma. Behind them are lesser shrines dedicated to Garuda, Nandi, and Hamsa, the *vahanas* (animal vehicles) of these major deities.

Candi Prambanan in Yogyakarta, Java, Indonesia, is the country's largest and most impressive Hindu temple complex. It is dedicated to the *Trimurti* (trinity), the three major deities at the top of the Hindu pantheon: Brahma (the creator), Vishnu (the preserver), and Shiva (the destroyer).

Construction of the complex began around the middle of the 9th century CE, during the reigns of the Sailendra and Sanjaya dynasties. Like the nearby Buddhist temple of Borobudur (see pp.256–257), the plan of Prambanan is of a mandala, or cosmic diagram, with the soaring spires characteristic of Hindu architecture here representing the mythical Mount Meru, home of gods.

Temple complex

Prambanan has two principal areas, separated by a wall: an inner area, containing the main temples and associated shrines; and an area outside this containing 224 smaller temples (many of which are damaged). The complex centers on the Shiva temple, in the inner area—at 154 ft (47 m) high, it is the site's largest temple. It is flanked by the smaller temples of Brahma and Vishnu. The walls of these three main temples are adorned with magnificent stone carvings illustrating scenes from the Hindu epic the *Ramayana*.



◁ GUARDIAN STATUE

A fearsome 9th-century *dvarapala*, or temple protector, with bulging eyes and a moustache, keeps watch outside the Prambanan temple complex.

THE SHIVA TEMPLE

The Shiva temple has five main rooms. Like most Hindu architecture, it was conceived as a symbol of the Hindu cosmos: the base of the temple (*bhurloka*) represents the human realm; the central section (*bhuvarloka*) is the realm of sages and truth seekers; and the top of the temple, the holiest section (*svarloka*), represents the realm of the gods.

